pathway for the cultivation of Japan and South Korea. In many ways, this period of adjustment laid the foundation for an India that could operate on multiple axis in international affairs with greater comfort.

This phase may have unfolded as India sought a way out of a difficult predicament when the postulates of its foreign policy were called into question. But it developed in due course into a larger defence of its strategic autonomy. Interestingly, it was when the polity was under real stress that its redlines acquired clarity, even internally. The first pressure point was on the nuclear weapon option and the initial challenge was to continue developing it without an open confrontation. The manner in which the Comprehensive Test Ban Treaty was framed finally left India with no choice but to eventually exercise its weapon option.

Similar challenges in safeguarding economic and developmental interests in the face of Western demands were evident in the negotiations on the TRIPS and the Kyoto Protocol. A domestic issue that added to India's vulnerability at this very juncture was the worsening situation in Jammu and Kashmir. Attempts to internationalize that and a threatened shift in the longstanding US position caused considerable concern. It is to the credit of that generation of leadership that a difficult predicament was resolved with considerable finesse. In some cases, long-pending course corrections such as upgrading relations with Israel helped. Through a combination of adjustments and initiatives, India's positioning at the end of the decade improved visibly, as indeed did its economy. The nuclear tests of 1998 and the declaration of weaponization stands out as a landmark, since this not only decisively resolved a persistent dilemma but also provided the attributes later on of a leading power.

The delay in doing so did permit Pakistan to equalize, but that country's political and economic shortcomings diminished the value of that step. A year later, the Kargil conflict provided an opportunity to address the Pakistani challenge again and do so with a demonstrated sense of responsibility. In the same period, the spread of the internet economy created a new bonding with the US and established India firmly in global circles as a tech power. The promise of Russia's revival with the accession of President Putin concluded the century on a promising note for India.